

Introduction

This guide is a short, original introduction to baking sourdough bread at home. It was written for this project as a small, clearly structured example corpus.

Each chapter below covers one part of the process, from building a starter to troubleshooting a loaf that did not rise.

Building a Starter

A sourdough starter is a mixture of flour and water that captures wild yeast and bacteria from the air and the flour itself.

To build one, mix equal parts flour and water in a jar, and feed it with the same amounts once a day for about a week, discarding half before each feeding.

A healthy starter roughly doubles in size a few hours after feeding, and smells pleasantly sour rather than harsh or like nail polish remover.

Mixing the Dough

Combine flour, water, salt, and a portion of active starter in a large bowl.

Rest the dough for thirty minutes so the flour fully absorbs the water, a step called autolyse, before kneading or folding it further.

Fold the dough over itself every thirty minutes for the first two hours to build strength without traditional kneading.

Shaping and Proofing

Once the dough has roughly doubled in bulk, turn it out and shape it into a tight round or oval loaf.

Place the shaped loaf in a floured basket and let it proof, either at room temperature for a few hours or in the refrigerator overnight for more flavor.

Baking

Preheat a covered pot in the oven to a high temperature, then carefully place the proofed loaf inside and score the top with a blade.

Bake covered for the first part of the bake to trap steam, then uncover to let the crust brown for the remainder.

Troubleshooting

A dense, flat loaf usually means the starter was not active enough, or the dough was underproofed before baking.

A loaf that spreads out flat instead of holding its shape usually means the dough was overproofed or shaped too loosely.

A pale crust that never browns usually means the oven was not preheated to a high enough temperature before baking.